



Buffel

Named after the Afrikaans word for “buffalo,” the Buffel was the first purpose-built mine-protected Armored Personnel Carrier. It was built in South Africa during the South African Border War, a series of conflicts that took place in South West Africa (now Namibia), Angola, and Zambia from 1966 to 1990.

WHILE MANY VEHICLES had used V- or boat-shaped hulls to deflect mine blasts away from their undersides—for example, the Saracen APC (see p.180)—the Buffel was the first vehicle to have the survivability of the driver and mounted infantry as the priority in the design brief. Its design led to the Mine-Resistant Ambush Protected concept (MRAP) in the 2000s, which resulted in tens of thousands of vehicles being built for use in Iraq and Afghanistan.

The Buffel was a development of the earlier Bosvark vehicle—a Mercedes Benz Unimog truck modified with a basic level of mine protection. The Buffel took the design further using the same Mercedes Benz U416-162 Unimog chassis, but with a driver’s position set high off the ground behind the front axle, and with bulletproof windows to the front and sides. The open-topped rear troop compartment could carry ten infantrymen, each with a four-point seat belt harness, back to back. Entry to the vehicle was over the sides of the compartment, which were hinged to allow the armor to be dropped down.



REAR VIEW



SPECIFICATIONS

Name	Buffel Armoured Personnel Carrier
Date	1978
Origin	South Africa
Production	Approx 2,400
Engine	Mercedes-Benz OM-352 diesel, 125 hp
Weight	6.7 tons (6.1 tonnes)
Main armament	None
Secondary armament	None
Crew	1 + 10
Armor thickness	Hull: unknown; windshield: 1.6 in (40 mm) armored glass

